occasional use of a limited number of aging manned aircraft in the region, especially when real-time interpretation of data was required.[31]

Roughly thirty minutes later, before word of the EP-3's downing had reached US Indo-Pacific Command in Hawaii, let alone Washington or Beijing, 13 nm northwest of Scarborough Shoal, the *Bertholf* (WMSL-750), a US Coast Guard cutter returning from a training mission along with the Japan Coast Guard *Kunigami*-class patrol vessel *Motobu*, out of Naha in Okinawa, was approached by a cutter-class armed Chinese Coast Guard (CCG) ship. After broadcasting warnings for the *Bertholf* and the *Motobu* to leave the area, the Chinese ship attempted to maneuver in front of the American ship, to turn its bow.[32] The CCG captain miscalculated and struck the *Bertholf* amidships, caving in the mess and one of its enlisted crew compartments. The *Bertholf* began taking on water and attempted to turn east toward the Philippines while emergency crews attempted to keep the ship afloat. The CCG ship immediately left the scene without rendering assistance. Six US sailors later were declared missing and presumed dead in the collision, while three Chinese CCG sailors were swept overboard and lost at sea.

Being the closest US naval vessel to the downed EP-3, the *Curtis Wilbur* raced toward the site of its crash, while the *Charleston* moved to assist the *Bertholf*. Nighttime darkness caused confusion for rescue and patrol operations on both sides. Two PLAN ships returned to the scene of the maritime collision to search for the lost Chinese seamen, coming in close quarters with the *Motobu*—which was helping in rescue operations to stabilize the American vessel—as well as with the littoral combat ship *Charleston*, which arrived several hours later. Mechanical trouble kept the *Bertholf* from making way under her own power, and she began to drift back toward PLAN vessels. In the darkness, US ships and the Japanese attempted to disengage with the Chinese vessels, while continually warning the other side to stand down so rescue operations could continue.

After several close encounters, one Type 052D Luyang III class PLAN destroyer, the *Taiyuan*, activated its fire-control radar and